It was tough to win the confidence of the French who initially looked down upon our men. There were even a few who found fault with Rene Morin, the commercial head, for having got a bunch of greenhorns into SEP just because the French wanted to do business with India. It is another matter that Morin, who stood by us during difficult times, had a technical qualification and confidence in Indian scientists. The coming years proved that Morin stood by us, from the turbulent days of signing the Viking contract to its execution and PSLV launch. Morin had been a friend of India worthy of at least a Padma Shri.

Dedication was the hallmark of our engineers in Vernon. Ramachandra Rao, who worked on a mathematical modelling of the Viking engine, continued to work despite a fracture he suffered. Rao had left his wife back in India as her father was ailing. Months later, when she joined Rao, her father had died. The couple kept this a private tragedy, and did not share it with us, lest Rao's work in Vernon be affected.

Besides sweat, our men had plenty of skills. Particularly two incidents proved our worth to the French, one demonstrated our skills, the other our knowledge. The former came from welder Samuel Raj. The uninitiated may consider a welder's job a lowly one, but engineers are indebted to a good welder. A good understanding of the behavior of metals and alloys gives him the foundation on which he can employ his skills that get better by the day. In other words, his job demands knowledge, dexterity and experience.

'I can weld like a dream, sir,' Raj said. And he was not boasting. He possessed all the qualities I mentioned, in abundance, and was a star at ISRO. And that's why I took him to Vernon. The welder's job here was quite challenging. For one, he had to work on AZ5, a tricky aluminium alloy. While a machine does inert gas welding at places like the injector through which the fuel and oxidiser go into the combustion chamber, a dome has to be manually welded onto the injector rim. Such is the caution employed that it takes four months to put the injector dome in place, if people worked in sixteen-hour-a-day shifts.

It was tough, but I was confident that Raj could pull it off. But there was a hitch. SEP and many aerospace industrial units in France allowed only